

coaches while trying to overcome the team's failures.

However, there is a welcome break in this trend as the tournament enters its 11th season. The Highlanders are reinventing themselves under the astute leadership of Juan Pedro Benali. The seasoned Spanish gaffer has had a long coaching career, a good part of it spent managing clubs in Morocco, an emerging power in world football. Drawing on all his expertise and knowledge, Benali has managed to assemble a NorthEast United side with a good balance of domestic and foreign talent.

NorthEast United made the biggest headlines at the start of the new season as Benali's boys defeated reigning ISL Shield champion Mohun Bagan Super Giant with a remarkable comeback to win the 133rd edition of the historic Durand Cup.

Does this create the perfect prelude to a successful ISL season? The coach responded with a philosophical answer: "You know time puts anyone in his place. Last season, time put us in our place. We missed many games, many points, and finally missed the play-off stage by a whisker. We have a young team that is learning. And we learn by slaps, by getting burned. We hope this season we don't do the same thing."

Benali felt that the small errors piled up to cause the big disappointment in the previous season. "Yeah, winning the Durand Cup gives us confidence and assurance that we are doing the right thing. But at the same time, we should not forget the 'slaps' we got last season. We have to keep that in mind as we plan for the long ISL season," he added.

Benali's words seemed to have resonated well with the team, as NorthEast United managed an injury-time goal to avoid defeat against Mohammedan Sporting in its first match. Benali's philosophy and tactical acumen seem to be setting the team on the path to success.

Elsewhere, his 'slap' analogy appears to have resonated even deeper within Mohun Bagan SG's



ranks. The Mariners saw their vessel slipping into the doldrums as the team played a succession of draws, making the start to its season rather uninspiring.

The winning rhythm deserted the ISL champion after it began the season under new coach Jose Molina with a 6-0 win against Indian Air Force in the Durand Cup group stage. Mohun Bagan beat Punjab FC and Bengaluru FC on penalties (after remaining tied in regulation time) to reach the final, where NorthEast United turned the tables on it and won the crown with successful conversions in the penalty shootout.

The ISL opener against Mumbai City FC also saw Mohun Bagan concede a two-goal lead to eventually end the match 2-2, before being held to a goalless draw by FC Ravshan of Tajikistan in its AFC Champions League Two group stage opener. The Salt Lake Stadium, the theatre of many success stories, suddenly became a stage of tragedy for Mohun Bagan SG. That was enough

Instant impact: NorthEast United made the biggest headlines at the start of the new season as Juan Pedro Benali's boys defeated reigning ISL Shield champion Mohun Bagan Super Giant to win its maiden Durand Cup.

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humiliation for a section of its fans, who blamed the coach for the team's setback and chanted "Go back Molina" after the insipid performance against Ravshan.

Odisha FC, FC Goa, and Kerala Blasters also received the proverbial smack on the face as they started their campaigns with home losses. It was a big shock for the home fans, as a defeat at the start of the tournament is never considered auspicious.

Among the reputed sides, Bengaluru FC and Jamshedpur FC seemed to buck the trend, with both teams picking up successive wins in consecutive match weeks, signalling their intent and ability.

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